

The Brush Care & Restoration Guide

A good sumi brush can last a decade if you treat it right. Here is how to clean, shape, store, and bring neglected brushes back to life.



Five minutes of care after each session is what buys a brush ten years.

A good sumi brush is not a disposable tool — it is an **instrument**. Cared for, it holds its needle-fine point for ten years and more. Neglected, it splays, stiffens, and loses its tip within weeks. The whole difference is a few quiet minutes after every session.

WHAT'S INSIDE THIS GUIDE

- ◆ How to wash and rinse so ink never dries deep in the bristles
- ◆ How to reshape the tip so it keeps a needle-sharp point for years
- ◆ Correct drying and storage — and the mistakes that ruin a brush in weeks
- ◆ How to revive a brush that has been splayed, stiffened, or neglected

Washing & Rinsing

Do this after every single session, without exception. Ink left in the bristles is what kills a brush — everything else is recoverable.

- 1 Rinse the moment you stop.** Dried ink is the enemy. Carry the brush straight to water before you clean anything else on the table — even a few minutes lets ink begin to set at the root.
- 2 Use lukewarm water — never hot.** Hot water softens the glue inside the ferrule and the brush starts to shed; cold water will not lift the ink. Lukewarm is the only safe temperature.
- 3 Clean from the root, not the tip.** Ink hides where the bristles meet the ferrule. Gently press and roll the base against your palm, working the colour outward toward the tip.
- 4 Rinse until the water runs clear.** Sumi ink is stubborn — expect two or three changes of water before it stops clouding. Grey water means ink is still in there.
- 5 Skip the soap.** Water alone for everyday cleaning. Soap strips the natural oils that keep bristles supple and springy — save it only for true restoration.
- 6 Blot, never wring.** Press the brush in a folded cloth or paper towel from root to tip. Twisting or wringing snaps bristles and breaks the point.

The golden rule: never leave a brush standing in the water bowl while you paint. Minutes of soaking swell the ferrule, loosen the glue, and bend the tip — rest it across the bowl's rim instead.

Reshaping The Tip

A sumi brush is bought for its point. Thirty seconds of shaping after each wash is what keeps that point needle-sharp for years.

- 1 **Reshape while damp, never dry.** Bristles only take a new shape while wet. Do this the moment you finish washing — once dry, the shape is set.
- 2 **Draw it to a point.** Pinch gently at the ferrule and pull your fingers toward the tip, coaxing every bristle inward into one single, fine point.
- 3 **Finish with a half-twist.** As you pull toward the tip, roll the brush a half-turn between your fingers — the way you would twist a strand of hair. That locks in the needle point.
- 4 **For long storage, set the point.** A whisper of weak starch water on the tip dries stiff and guards the point — exactly how a new brush arrives. Simply rinse it out before the next use.
- 5 **Hang it to hold the shape.** A freshly pointed brush keeps its shape only if it dries hanging tip-down — which is where correct storage begins.

Where to find starch water: the stiff “sizing” in a new brush is rice or seaweed starch. A few drops of water stirred into a little cooked-rice residue — or a dab of laundry starch — does the same job. Use it only on brushes going into long storage.

Drying & Storage

This is where most beginners quietly ruin good brushes — not through hard use, but through the wrong few hours of drying.

WHAT BEGINNERS GET WRONG

- ✗ **Standing it upright, bristles up.** Water runs down into the ferrule, rots the glue and the bristle roots from the inside.
- ✗ **Leaving it flat on the table.** The tip dries bent and crooked, and one whole side of the brush flattens permanently.
- ✗ **Drying it in sun or on a radiator.** Heat cracks the bamboo handle and turns supple bristles dry and brittle.
- ✗ **Re-capping it with the plastic tube.** The sleeve it shipped in traps moisture against damp bristles — mildew within days.

- 1 **Hang it bristle-down.** Use a brush hanger, a clip, or a loop of string through the handle's hanging hole. Water drains away from the ferrule and the tip dries perfectly straight.
- 2 **Dry it in open, moving air.** Room temperature, out of direct sun, away from any heat source. Patient air-drying is what keeps bamboo and bristle healthy.
- 3 **Wait until it is bone-dry to store it.** A brush that is even slightly damp will grow mildew the moment it goes into a closed roll or drawer.
- 4 **Store flat in a bamboo roll.** A bamboo brush mat (makisu) lets air move through, protects the tip, and keeps the brush flat — the traditional home for a resting brush.

PART FOUR

Reviving A Neglected Brush

A brush that is stiff, splayed, or clogged is rarely finished. Patience and lukewarm water bring most of them back.

Stiff with dried ink

THE FIX

Soak the bristles only — keep the ferrule above the water — in lukewarm water for a few hours, or overnight. Then gently work the softened ink out from the root, rinse, and repeat until the brush moves freely. A drop of mild conditioner speeds along a badly clogged brush.

Splayed or lost its point

THE FIX

Wash it through completely, reshape it to a point (Part Two), and set the tip with starch water. Hang it to dry while it holds that shape. Expect two or three cycles — gentle, repeated coaxing is what wins a point back.

Stiff, brittle bristles

THE FIX

The natural oils have dried out. A short soak with a pea-sized dab of hair conditioner restores the spring — rinse it out well, reshape, and dry as normal.

Mildew spots

THE FIX

Wash once with a single drop of mild soap, rinse exhaustively until no trace remains, and dry fully in open, moving air before it goes anywhere near storage.

WHEN TO LET A BRUSH GO

Some damage is permanent. If the **bristles are snapped or heat-melted**, or the **ferrule sheds bristles** every time you paint because its glue has failed, the brush is past saving. Retire it with thanks — and treat the next one from day one with everything in this guide.

Clean it, point it, hang it — and a good brush will outlast every painting you make with it.